

targeted the terrain with defoliants and Rome Plows (armored bulldozers) to destroy vegetation that could conceal insurgent activity.

In terms of casualties, territory, and war materiel captured, the operation was a resounding victory for the United States. However, the long-term goal of driving North Vietnamese and Viet Cong forces into unpopulated areas, where they could be destroyed from the air, was not met. They did retreat into an unpopulated area, but, as in Operation Attleboro, it was across the Cambodian border, beyond the reach of bombing authorized by Washington at this point in the war.

Cedar Falls also resulted in the demolition of an entire village, Ben Suc, which the Viet Cong used as a supply station on the Saigon River. Some 6,000 Vietnamese civilians, two-thirds of them children, were taken to “New Life Villages” by the ARVN. These were essentially refugee camps run by the South Vietnamese government. Families that once sustained themselves through farming suddenly struggled to find food. Meanwhile, US forces burned, then plowed under and bombed, Ben Suc, ensuring that the refugees could not return to their village.

“The villages were just dust—**ashes and dust.**”

COLONEL HARRY SUMMERS, ESSAY IN VIETNAM MAGAZINE, 1988



Firepower

US soldiers on a “Zippo track”—an armored personnel carrier equipped with a flame thrower—incinerate an area of the Iron Triangle during Operation Cedar Falls in January 1967.